

Primary Source Reading: The Decalogue and the Sermon on the Mount

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.02 — The Universal Witness King James Version

Before you read: These two passages are separated by well over a thousand years — Exodus 20 dates to the ancient Israelite tradition, and Matthew 5–7 records teaching attributed to Jesus in the first century CE — but both belong to the same broader tradition and are worth reading together. As you read, notice how Exodus states its rules as direct commands, while the Sermon on the Mount repeatedly takes an existing rule and asks what lies underneath it.

The Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:1–17)

And God spake all these words, saying, I am the LORD thy God, which have brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage. Thou shalt have no other gods before me. Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image... Thou shalt not take the name of the LORD thy God in vain... Remember the sabbath day, to keep it holy... Honour thy father and thy mother: that thy days may be long upon the land which the LORD thy God giveth thee. Thou shalt not kill. Thou shalt not commit adultery. Thou shalt not steal. Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbour. Thou shalt not covet thy neighbour's house, thou shalt not covet thy neighbour's wife, nor his manservant, nor his maidservant, nor his ox, nor his ass, nor any thing that is thy neighbour's.

The Beatitudes (Matthew 5:3–10)

Blessed are the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are they that mourn: for they shall be comforted. Blessed are the meek: for they shall inherit the earth. Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness: for they shall be filled. Blessed are the merciful: for they shall obtain mercy. Blessed are the pure in heart: for they shall see God. Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God. Blessed are they which are persecuted for righteousness' sake: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

Taking a Commandment Further (Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28)

Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, Thou shalt not kill; and whosoever shall kill shall be in danger of the judgment: But I say unto you, That whosoever is angry with his brother without a cause shall be in danger of the judgment...

Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, Thou shalt not commit adultery: But I say unto you, That whosoever looketh on a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart.

Love Your Enemies (Matthew 5:43-45)

Ye have heard that it hath been said, Thou shalt love thy neighbour, and hate thine enemy. But I say unto you, Love your enemies, bless them that curse you, do good to them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use you, and persecute you; That ye may be the children of your Father which is in heaven: for he maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust.

The Golden Rule (Matthew 7:12)

Therefore all things whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do ye even so to them: for this is the law and the prophets.

After you read: Notice the pattern in the Sermon on the Mount passages: each one opens with an existing rule (“Thou shalt not kill,” “Thou shalt not commit adultery,” “love thy neighbour, and hate thine enemy”) and then pushes past the outward act to the inward disposition behind it. As you fill in your comparison chart, consider: is this a different moral demand than the Decalogue’s, or a deeper reading of the same one?